

sion. The ability to hold such a dark, difficult moment and turn it into something beautiful was really a revelation."

That same urge to make sense of her feelings through music led her to write the songs on *Poetry Ceylon*. Veena was touring with the album across India when COVID-19 hit, stranding her and her band in Vadodara. The pandemic years were a time of great uncertainty and disruption. She had to shut down her ecological research studio in Goa and leave her projects unfinished. She ended up stuck in Europe for a year because of the lack of flights home. And in 2021, she was diagnosed with a serious, life-threatening illness.

ADITI VEENA, OR 'DITTY', EXCELS AT CRAFTING DELICATE TUNES THAT PULL AT THE STRINGS OF OUR RELATIONSHIP WITH THE NATURAL WORLD

But there were positive developments too. A chance encounter with German artist Keno Langbein and Austrian producer and percussionist David Raddish—who were visiting India for a project with German NGO Viva con Agua—led to the formation of artist collective Faraway Friends, which released a debut LP titled *Rain is Coming* in 2021. She also found love and moved to Berlin last spring. All that, as well as her ongoing engagement with environmental concerns, finds its way onto the songs she's written for *Skin*. "I had written the title track first, as a poem to myself about how we treat our bodies like machines, and how we treat the earth body like that too," says Veena. "I wanted to talk about the skin of the earth—the biosphere—which is the only place where we know life exists."

Veena is now gearing up for a pre-release tour across India this December in anticipation of the EP's release, and also has a summer tour across Europe planned for next year. In line with her ecological concerns, Ditty's tours aim to be carbon neutral, like her 2022 Songs for Forests tour that kept emissions low by avoiding flights, performing in parks and gardens, and planting trees. It's a vision of touring that Ditty hopes to champion. "We have to realise that our actions are impacting the planet, and ourselves," she says. "We need to focus on healing the planet." ■

Bhanuj Kappal



2004, Zenzi opened its doors. And earned a name not for the usual reasons of great cuisine or an exceptional bartender but for the kind of events that happened there. There was music, of course. But no Bollypop or trending chart music: DJs came and did their sets, and soon there was live music too, big names but also experimental acts that went on to be big names, hopeful singer-songwriters standing alone at the microphone, and then poetry, spoken word, comedy, dance, performance.

"Zenzi was all about how much we can experiment," says Anil Kably, "and that sensibility still lives"

Zenzi was perhaps too good to last: plagued by regular complaints from residents of the area, it closed in 2011, living on only in the tales told by its loyal clientele.

But this week, restaurateur Anil Kably, one of Zenzi's erstwhile partners, and poet, musician and novelist Jeet Thayil, one of its regulars, both as patron and performer, have teamed up to launch a music and literature festival, Five Oh, named for Bandra's postal code—which feels like a resurrection of the Zenzi spirit.

"It was Anil's idea," Thayil says, "throw a party, a one-of-a-kind event, and see what happens." The initial thought, Kably says, was an indulgence, a private event, from where it snowballed. "From that seed," Thayil says, "grew this multi-canopied, shade-giving tree called Five Oh. It's the kind of thing that hasn't been done before, which is what makes it worth doing. Between us, we've been to more than our share of concerts and literary events. We know what we'd like to see. Musicians and writers thrown together, sometimes in an improvised performance context, taking high-wire leaps without a net. Of course, it's a risk, but what would be the point otherwise?"

"Zenzi was all about how much we can experiment," says Kably, "and that sensibility still lives. I am very much more at home with being on the fringes. That is what we did, and it is how I live my life in some ways." Thayil agrees that Zenzi was at the back of their minds. "It was such a time of experimentation, improvisation, discovery. Probably marked us for life." ■

Peter Griffin

The line-up: *Novelist Devika Rege and poet Aekta Khubchandani on writing about the city, moderated by Supriya Nair; conservation architect Vikas Dilawari and filmmaker Aashim Ahluwalia, moderated by Genesia Alves, on filming the city; spoken word by Mandovi Menon, Denzil Smith, Kamal Trilok Singh, Aekta Khubchandani, Imaad Shah and Jeet Thayil; music by Signal W, Honey's Dead, and HMT.*
Five Oh: A Festival of Music and Literature *will be held at Pioneer Hall, Bandra, Mumbai, on November 18 (4 pm onwards). Entry: Rs 500. Tickets via Skillbox. See @fiveoh_bombay on Instagram for more.*